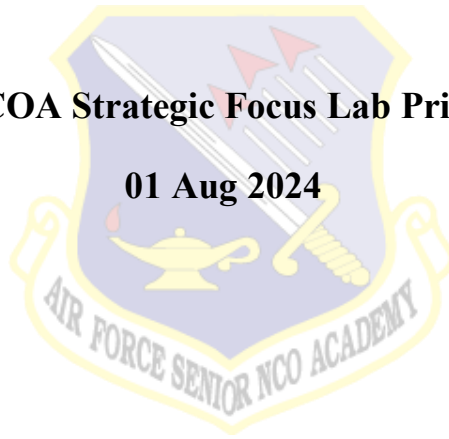


Module 4 – Strategic Focus Lab Primer

SNCOA Strategic Focus Lab Primer

01 Aug 2024



Purpose: The 2022 National Military Strategy (NMS) emphasis on “**Strategic Discipline**” involves prioritizing and aligning Joint Force operations, activities, and investments in accordance with policy guidance and strategic objectives. Strategic Discipline hinges on a comprehensive understanding of the strategic landscape, including awareness of adversaries, allies, partners interests and the evolving nature of warfare. The purpose of the Strategic Focus Lab is to equip students at the AFSNCOA with insights into focus areas that can feed strategic challenges, and their implications within the Air Force.

Details: Considering the practical implications associated with these focus areas/topics, conduct research, and share insights regarding possible courses of action which address challenges associated with the focus area/topics. The culminating capstone assignment will be a group Plan of Action briefing not to exceed 45 minutes on Day of Education (DOE) 22. Each group will use the associated module assignments and tasks listed below to prepare for the culminating group brief.

Instructions:

Module 1

DOE 3: Instructor Task

- **Instructors will form student groups** based on students’ Competing Values Framework (CVF) profile, **ensuring cognitive diversity by providing a mix of CVF profiles in each group.** If a CVF assessment is not available, students will have reflected on where they fall within the CVF during pre-reading for the Creative Thinker lesson.
- **CVF Profiles:** <https://denverleadership.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/01/Competing-Values-Framework.pdf>
- Strategic Focus Lab groups will have no less than 3 and no more than 4 students.
- Once groups are formed, notify students then have groups use the Focus Areas and Example Challenges attachment to select a focus area/topic for their group from the pre-approved list by DOE 5. Focus areas/topics shall not be duplicated within the flight and will be approved on a first come first serve basis.
- *Note: Focus Areas/Topics are derived from the Air University Research Topics List via The Office of Sponsored Programs.*
- *Note 2: Use **Attachment 2 - Strategic Focus Lab Sign-up** to display student groups (digitally or physically in the flight room) and for students to annotate Group Focus Areas/Topics, Individual Unique Challenges & Group Challenges for the Module 4 Plan of Action briefing.*

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DOE 5: Group Task

- **Groups will select their focus area/topic** and notify instructors by the start of DOE 5.
- *Note: Individual challenges associated with group focus areas/topics do not need to be identified yet.*

DOE 5: Instructor Task

- **Instructors will approve all groups' focus areas** by Close of Business (COB) DOE 5.
- Once approved, groups will conduct research and analysis using literature reviews, historical case studies, interviews, etc. to understand the complexities of the focus area.

Things to consider during the focus area selection phase:

- What is the past, present and future state of the focus area/topic?
- How does the Air Force currently experience the focus area/topic?
- What is the impact of the focus area/topic on your organization's mission readiness and/or culture?
- As an SNCO, what is your experience with the focus area/topic?
- *Note: If students are unable to discover substantiating evidence to support their focus area/topic, they may choose to change focus areas/topics with instructor approval no later than DOE 8.*

DOE 8: Individual Student Task

- Individual **students will identify a unique challenge** associated with their group's focus area/topic by DOE 8. The unique challenge feeds the Module 2 individual assignment.
- *Note: in a group of four students, all students research the same focus area/topic, but each student identifies a unique challenge related to the focus area/topic **which affects their organization.***

DOE 8: Instructor Task

- Instructors will **conduct a progress check** to verify students are able to prepare for their Module 2 assignment.
- Instructors will **approve students' unique challenges** associated with their group's focus area/topic by COB DOE 8.

Module 2

Module 2: Individual Assignment

Individually, students will identify a unique challenge (see example challenges) they experience associated with their group's selected focus area/topic. The term "unique" is understood as not duplicating example challenges listed as examples in the Strategic Focus Lab Guide and not duplicating challenges used by other members of their group. Once students have identified a challenge, they conduct research to understand the details associated with it and the impact it has on their organization. Students will also discuss how their challenge connects to policy, strategy, and doctrine as well as elements of the Joint Interagency Intergovernmental Multinational (JIIM) environment. Reference the elements listed below and the associated assignment instructions/evaluation instrument to craft their individual background paper. Focus area challenges must have relevance to the students' organizations.

Due on or about DOE 15 (see course schedule)

- 4-part paper
- 4 page maximum
- This is an **individual assignment**; the unique challenge will be different for each student in the group

Module 4 – Strategic Focus Lab Primer

1. Background and Details

- Identify and develop a challenge associated with your groups selected focus area
- Introduce your associated challenge and discuss its importance
- Identify the history, significance and previous research regarding your challenge
- Identify the existing approaches and key stakeholders regarding your challenge
- Identify key issues associated with your challenge, to include: barriers, unresolved problems, ethical implications and resource constraints (e.g. time, money, manpower)

2. Organizational Considerations

- Explain how the Air Force currently experiences your challenge
- Explain how your challenge does or could impact any Major Command (MAJCOM) and/or Combatant Command (CCMD)
- Explain how your challenge does or could impact your organization's ability to achieve its mission and/or vision

3. Policy, Strategy, Doctrine Connections

- Explain how your challenge affects the United States from the standpoint of at least one of the following:
 - National Security Strategy
 - National Defense Strategy
 - National Military Strategy
- Identify additional policies, strategies and/or doctrine which currently exists and impacts your challenge
- Explain how your challenge impacts the United States' ability to achieve its national interests
- Explain which Instruments of National Power the United States can leverage to address your challenge

4. IIIM Connections

- Discuss which Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs), Intergovernmental Organizations (IGOs) and/or Interagency Organization are involved or have potential to be involved with your challenge
- Discuss which joint service components and/or coalition partners are involved or have potential to be involved with your challenge
- Discuss the implications of your challenge on the IIIM environment, if left unresolved. Include threats and/or vulnerabilities

Module 3

Module 3: Group Task (Culmination of Module 3)

Considering what was covered in Module 3, **groups will identify one challenge associated with their group's focus area.** The challenge may be an existing one identified individually and submitted in the Module 2 assignment or a new challenge identified and/or refined through group collaboration.

Module 4

Module 4: Group Task (Focus Lab Research)

Groups will use the 16 hours of Strategic Focus Lab Research to develop two (2) Courses of Action (COAs) to address their selected challenge. Groups will then Red Team their two COAs to determine the most effective, then develop the following products to support the Strategic Focus Lab Plan of Action briefing due in Module 4. The most effective COA will be the COA used to develop Plan of Action briefings due on DOE 22.

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1. COA Development

Create two distinct COAs addressing your challenge. During COA development consider the following:

- Desired outcomes
- Constraints and restraints
- Feasibility
- Risks
- Ethical and/or legal considerations
- Existing or new policy, procedure, etc.
- Resources
- Cost
- Availability
- Manpower
- Time
- Stakeholder input
- Integration and collaboration in the JIIM environment
- Negotiation
- Conflict resolution
- Effective communication

2. Red Team COA Results

- The challenges, risks or lessons learned identified because of Red Teaming
- How the selected COA was refined due to Red Teaming
- COA selection and why

DOE 21: Group Task (DUE COB DOE 21)

Upload the following to the LMS:

- COA descriptions and analysis
- COA comparison criteria
- Red Teaming results
- COA selected with justification

DOE 22: Group Assignment

Groups will select the best COA from their group to create a detailed **Plan of Action** addressing the group's challenge. This is delivered as a group briefing with three graded areas not to exceed 45 minutes. To note, anywhere the word "Describe" is encountered, there is a requirement to provide information and details in a straightforward manner. Whereas "Discuss" involves analyzing, interpreting, and critically examining a topic in greater depth. Reference the elements listed below and the associated assignment instructions/evaluation instrument to craft group briefings.

1. Analysis of the challenge

- Provide a summary of the current state of your focus area challenge
 - Introduce your challenge and describe why it's important
 - Discuss the impact of your challenge at the strategic level
 - Identify key issues associated with your challenge
 - Identify existing approaches to your challenge

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- Identify the implications of the challenge, if left unresolved

2. Detailed plan of action

- Identify and discuss
 - The plan of action
 - The expected outcomes
 - How it is unique from existing approaches
 - How it does or may resolve the challenge
- Identify and discuss the Policy, Strategy and Doctrine that exists to support your plan
- Identify and discuss the role or potential role of Non-Governmental Organizations and/or Intergovernmental Organizations in the plan
- Identify and discuss the role of joint service components and/or coalition partners in the plan
- Identify and describe the required resources to support the plan
- Identify and describe key milestones associated with implementation of the plan
- Identify and describe the associated risks **and** how you plan to mitigate them
- Identify and describe the associated performance metrics to support the plan

3. Leadership Application

- Explain the integration and synchronization required of leadership at all levels to implement the plan
- Explain the key virtues a senior enlisted leader should possess to effectively implement this plan
- Explain the specific elements of critical and/or creative thinking your group leveraged to analyze the challenge
- Explain the specific elements of critical and/or creative thinking your group leveraged to develop the plan

Strategic Focus Lab Primer – Attachment 1 Focus Areas and Example Challenges

Focus Areas/Topics	Example Challenges
Women, Peace in Security (WPS)	<i>How might you include considerations of WPS in peace keeping missions?</i>
The Strategic Impacts of Misinformation and Disinformation	<i>How can Department of Defense (DoD) leaders prevent the negative effects of misinformation and disinformation?</i>
China's Use of Soft Power	<i>Considering China's use of soft power, particularly its use of economic and diplomatic power, how does the United States maintain a competitive edge?</i>
Roles and Functions of the USAF	<i>What are the future strategic opportunities and vulnerabilities that could impact the role and function of the USAF?</i>
Conventional-Nuclear Integration (CNI) Capabilities of US Allies	<i>How would cooperation on CNI with allies impact deterrence?</i>
Workforce Dynamics	<i>What innovation techniques can you apply to address contemporary issues such as generational differences or remote work?</i>
Improving Integration with US Allies and Partners	<i>How could the United States devote effort and resources to improving integrations with its allies and partners using a whole of nation approach?</i>
Ethics in Artificial Intelligence (AI)	<i>How might we leverage the use of AI while mitigating ethical implications?</i>
Industrial Preparedness for Competition	<i>How might the United States seek to transform a relatively consolidated defense industry to meet new military challenges that are emerging under conditions very different from the Cold War and the Global War on Terror?</i>
Civil and Military Collaboration in Space	<i>How can the US military best take advantage of the domestic space industry to enhance its capabilities?</i>
Establishing Flexible Logistics	<i>The Department of the Air Force is continuing its “initiatives focused on more agile, resilient, and survivable energy logistics—from bulk strategic supplies to deliveries at the tactical edge.” How do we create more agile, resilient, and survivable logistics?</i>
Agile Talent Management	<i>What agile talent management framework should be put in place to support career-long development across a diverse force and retain talent?</i>
Air Mobility in a Contested Environment	<i>How can Air Mobility Command plan to operate in kinetic/contested environment?</i>
Strategic Leadership	<i>How do leadership practices need to adapt to the changing character of war?</i>
Leadership in Joint All Domain Operations (JADO)	<i>For success in JADO, how and when should a joint culture be inculcated into military leaders?</i>

Strategic Focus Lab Primer – Attachment 1 Focus Areas and Example Challenges

Modernization of Military Education	<i>How can Professional Military Education (PME) evolve to handle changes in the character of warfare?</i>
Joint All Domain Command and Control (JADC2) / Combined JADC2	What does JADC2/CJADC2 mean for coalition and interagency partners?
Strategic Blind Spots in Modern Conflict	What role do previous operations play to provide valuable insights to help the DoD avoid pitfalls and ready us for future conflicts?
Space and the Warfighting Mindset	How does the Space Force develop a "warfighting" mindset?
Electronic Warfare (EW) Awareness	With an emergence of EW threats (for example: loss of Global Positioning System, satellite systems etc.), how does the Air Force re-instill a culture of EW awareness throughout the force?
Innovative Training	How might the Air Force explore creative or innovative training and development methods to increase performance?
Technological Advancements on Warfare	How can the USAF leverage emerging technology to increase superiority in the air domain?
Cyber's Impact on Integrated Deterrence	How might offensive and defensive cyber capabilities be implemented into existing or new risk mitigation frameworks to manage strategic stability?

Strategic Focus Lab Primer – Attachment 2 Reflection Questions

Question 1: Considering the unique challenge associated with your Module 2 briefing, how might you communicate this challenge to your leadership?

(Optional) Use the SEE-I format for the question above

State: *I would communicate the challenge to leadership by:*

Elaborate: *The reason for doing so is:* OR *In other words:*

Exemplify (examples): *For example:*

Illustrate: *This is similar to:* OR *This is like:*

Question 2: What were some strengths you learned about yourself while completing the Strategic Focus Lab within your group?

Question 3: What were some challenges you experienced during group work? How could you mitigate those challenges in the future?

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Strategic Focus Lab Primer – Attachment 4 Resources

Student Preparation:

N/A

Additional Resources (for increased understanding):

See resources for previous modules/lessons